in fact paid two visits to Delhi in September 2022 to meet Sonia and Rahul Gandhi to cement his stand.

These claims by the JD(U) are not entirely out of place. In the past, Nitish has openly favoured Rahul for the top job and also reached out to regional satraps like Arvind Kejriwal of the Aam Aadmi party (AAP), Mamata Banerjee of the Trinamool Congress (TMC) and Akhilesh Yadav of the Samajwadi party (SP)—whose political success owe a lot to pushing the Congress to the margins in their respective states—and made them agree to work with the Grand Old Party. It's also generally agreed among allies that if not for the Bihar CM's tireless campaign in the initial

THE JD(U) FEELS CONGRESS IS NOT APPRECIATIVE ENOUGH OF NITISH'S EFFORTS IN RAISING THE I.N.D.I.A. BLOC

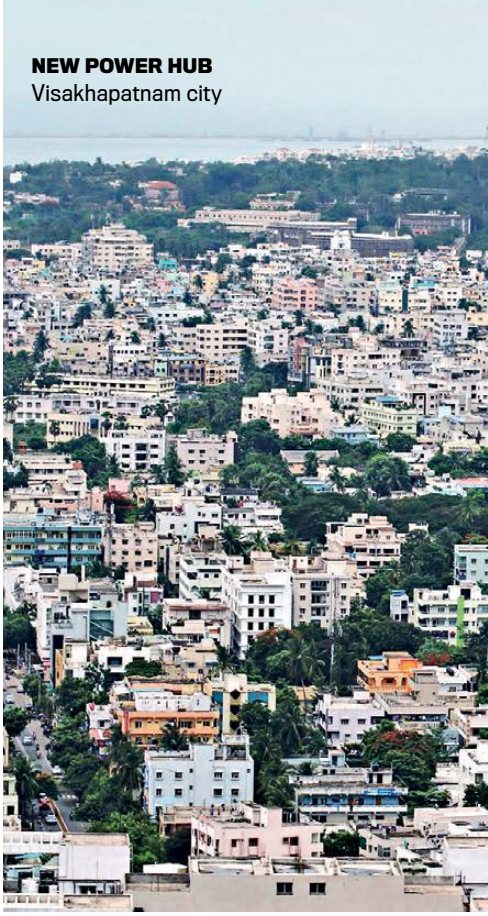
stages, INDIA may not have fructified as an alliance the way it has.

"Nitishji has refused to be the prime ministerial face of the alliance, so there was no surprise when he also refused to take on the job of INDIA bloc convenor. The Congress has a spring in its step now after the Karnataka win, but shouldn't it have proposed him as the alliance convenor?" asks the JD(U) leader.

Some senior JD(U) leaders also want Nitish to keep his candidacy alive in case the situation opens up post election. "Given his acceptability across the board, Nitishji can emerge as the dark horse," says the JD(U) leader. On his part, Nitish has remained steadfastly with the Opposition alliance, but a few of his recent decisions—from opposing the INDIA ban on alleged '*godi* media' TV anchors to supporting the women's reservation bill (even though alliance partner Rashtriya Janata Dal (RJD) described it as lip service)—has shown that the he is unwilling to give up his image of a politician who keeps "independent views".

Nitish's advantage stems from the fact that he holds the key to a state where he had ensured massive victories for the NDA, as part of that alliance, in the previous two Lok Sabha polls—in 2019, that gave the NDA 39 seats out of 40. This time, the BJP will not have the luxury of a divided opposition and Nitish and Lalu Yadav (RJD patriarch) are together a formidable opposition. Union home minister Amit Shah's visit to Bihar on September 16 again underlined the JD(U) chief's place in the scheme of things. Shah appeared to be trying to create a division between the vote banks of Nitish and Lalu, largely sparing the former while going hammer and tongs at the RJD.

The BJP is well aware that if the committed vote banks of the RJD and JD(U) vote in tandem, the MGB (*mahagathbandhan*) could steamroll the NDA. In the past too, the same alliance of Nitish, Lalu and Congress had decimated the saffron coalition in the 2015 assembly poll. Beyond the subtle overtures to Nitish in Shah's speech, the BJP is also trying to wean away the Kushwaha vote from Nitish's arsenal of supporters. To that end, the party had installed Kushwaha leader Samrat Choudhary as state unit president in March and has also roped in Upendra Kushwaha (head of the Rashtriya Lok Samta Party). Kushwahas (or Koeris) are the 'Kush' of Bihar's numerically significant Luv-Kush bloc that has been the bedrock of Nitish's social support base. For the Kurmis, the 'Luv', Nitish, of course, is the first love. Analysts say the 'Nitish for PM' pitch could be an attempt to undermine the BJP's efforts and keep the Kushwaha vote staunchly behind the CM. ■



NEW POWER HUB
Visakhapatnam city

By Amarnath K. Menon

Nearly a decade after knowing it would lose Hyderabad, Andhra Pradesh is finally set to move into its own capital. Chief minister Y.S. Jagan Mohan Reddy is all ready to operate from Visakhapatnam as the state's administrative headquarters. This momentous shift, set to begin on Dussehra on October 23, auspicious for new beginnings, will see Jagan move into an office in the port city overlooking the Bay of Bengal. At a cabinet meeting on September 20, the CM ordered constitution of the committees that would expedite the shifting process and ensure a smooth transition.

For over three years, Jagan has advocated this move as part of his ambitious three-capital plan, but legal obstacles have impeded progress. The Andhra Pradesh High Court ruled that the state government lacked the legislative authority to decide on the capital's relocation and mandated the time-bound development of Amaravati. The government challenged the decision in the Supreme Court, which is expected to address these matters in December.